‘I’ll get you Rs 1 crore,’ Dhawan continued. ‘Go make the engine.’

I was not too excited yet, for this ad hoc measure meant little more than delaying Vikas’s funeral.

‘But what will you do it with the engine if there is no project to fire and fly it?’

‘You just make the engine.’ Dhawan was curt.

I started the process of procuring material, and this proved to be tough since virtually every piece had to be imported. I had foreseen this day when we were in Vernon, and had been sending our scientists to visit the facilities of component makers for SEP. This was as much for their education as for establishing a rapport with the component manufacturers who would be of use to us later. The UK-based *Avica* made metallic bellows, which are joints with great strength and flexibility; *Le Joint Francais* made ‘O’ rings, which went into virtually every joint; *Casa* in Spain was the supplier of tibia, a valve feed-line joint. We had made enough acquaintances in these companies, but when we finally needed the components, they cited a practical problem: it would not be viable for them to supply in small numbers.

After much pleading and pulling strings, we managed to get most of the components, but a particular variant of aluminium was hard to get. We needed 20 kg of it, but the supplier would not give anything less than a tonne. There was only one man to go to. Rene Morin not only arranged for the aluminium, he did not even charge for it. When I asked for the bill, the good old friend said, ‘No bill, only goodwill.’

But when the consignment landed in India without a bill, our Customs department was not amused.

‘Why are the French sending gifts to ISRO?’ a Customs officer asked.

I lost patience. There was no point in educating the officer on the Indo-French friendship.

‘Release the consignment or face consequences.’ I blew my fuse.

No department had the courage to hold back for long the property of ISRO, which was by now under the department of space that reported directly to the Prime Minister. Customs obliged.